Africa 69 (4), 1999

THE BARRACUDA'S TALE: TRAWLERS, THE INFORMAL SECTOR AND A STATE OF CLASSIFICATORY DISORDER OFF THE NIGERIAN COAST

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Over the past two decades the subject of Nigerian food production has invited critical scrutiny from scholars in the related fields of anthropology, political science and development studies (Bates 1981; Beckman and Andrae, 1986; Clough, 1981; Guyer, 1987). Many studies were prompted by the realisation that the unfaltering rate of urban expansion coupled with the dramatically enhanced purchasing power of the naira at the height of the oil boom had profound implications for the organisation of rural producers as they switched from cultivating export cash crops, such as cocoa, to provisioning urban markets with food produce. These studies were predicated on the realisation that the models of analysis used in the first phase of post-independence development efforts, which distinguished between modern and traditional sectors (Boeke, 1953; Rostow, 1960), were rapidly becoming inadequate for describing socio-economic processes in both urban and rural areas. Intervention in the market for the benefit of politically volatile urban consumers (Bates, 1981), the intrusion of transnational companies, imported technology and the consequences of changing consumer patterns (Beckman and Andrae, 1986), and the agility of some farmers in meeting new marketing opportunities (Guyer, 1987; Clough, 1981) demonstrated the complexity of Nigeria's food economy. Successive World Bank studies went to great lengths to substantiate the widely held assumption that Nigeria's agricultural sector was suffering a sharp decline throughout the 1970s and 1980s. Yet, following a comprehensive reinterpretation of the data, it emerged that Nigeria's farmers had in fact expanded their production during that period (Forrest, 1993). This article deals with another area of food production which registered dramatic, yet entirely under-reported, increases throughout the 1970s and on into the Structural Adjustment-stricken 1980s: fisheries. It is a first attempt at sketching the conditions of artisanal fisheries along the Nigerian coastline and, on the basis of these insights from the fishing sector, a contribution to the debate on the character and quality of Nigeria's political economy.

While the use of the term 'traditional sector' has been largely expunged from academic discourse, the persuasive power of contrastive dichotomies has resurfaced in different models, one of which was gaining wide circulation in the 1970s. It originated in two simultaneous studies, one by an anthropological researcher in Ghana, the other by the International Labour Office in Kenya, on employment patterns in African cities (Hart, 1973; ILO, 1972). Both concluded that, in spite of massive structural unemployment, the bulk of the working population in Accra and Nairobi were not idle, and indeed could hardly afford to be. Instead, people eked out a living beyond the official employment charts of statisticians and economists through a range of activities in what was suggestively called the 'informal sector'. The discovery of 'informality' proved a spectacular triumph for anthropological research methods, as it demonstrated in graphic detail the inadequacy of macro-economic planning tools to account for the socio-economic situation of Africa's urban poor. As it gave expression to a phenomenon which 'had eluded economists, statisticians, national accountants, taxmen, policy makers and planners [though] it operated every day before their very eyes' (Grey-Johnson, 1992: 65),[1] informality made an immediate impact on anthropological and development discourse. Within a few years the informality paradigm had spawned a sub-discipline in economic anthropology, and was incorporated into the research work of the international agencies. The UN agencies, the World Bank, the IMF and the Overseas Development Administrations of most donor nations subsequently commissioned thousands of informal sector studies in virtually every developing country.

By promising policy planners and theoreticians sudden access to the 'grass roots' the informality paradigm came to be used in the management of poverty by agency professionals, and to substantiate the ideological positions of theoreticians: by defining the informal sector either as a reservoir of the entrepreneurial spirit (the neo-liberal view) or as the desperate response of marginalised workers to systematic exploitation (the revised Marxist perspective).[2] Yet, as informality could never shake off its overwhelmingly urban connotation, it has failed to take root in the literature on rural economies.

It is therefore interesting to note the classificatory alternative which has been developed in the literature on the fishing sector, which distinguishes artisanal from industrial fisheries. In spite of the differences in nomenclature and the peculiar characteristics of the aquatic setting the two schemas—formal/informal and industrial/artisanal—coincide on a number of defining features. Industrial fisheries are capital-intensive, use imported technology, are market-oriented and subject to government regulation. Artisanal fisheries, by contrast, fit the definition of informal sector enterprises, in that they are labour intensive, make use of indigenous technology and operate outside the supervision of government agencies. While the terms are widely used in the sub-discipline of maritime anthropology, little has been published as yet on artisanal fishing communities in Nigeria, estimated to comprise some 200,000 fishermen (Haakenson, 1992). Most Nigerian sources concentrate on lake, lagoon and riverine fisheries (Ajayi, 1991;

[1] One of the first achievements of informality was to make sense of the economically inexplicable: on a *per capita* income of $100 why were these people not dead? That resort to informality as a problem-solving quick fix was not the preserve of development scholars was demonstrated in 1992 by Italian statisticians, who included an estimated contribution of the 'informal sector' to inflate the country's GDP and leapfrog into third place in the league table of European economies.

[2] In anthropology the banishment of the term 'traditional sector' was completed by growing awareness of the changing nature of tradition (Hobsbawm and Ranger, 1983) and of the ideological implications of denying a historic dynamic to people in developing countries (Fabian, 1983).

Anetekhan, 1983; Avoseh, 1993), with only a cursory mention of the fishing in coastal waters along some 50 km of sea beach between Lagos and Badagry. This article therefore aims to fill the gap in the literature by presenting material from Nigerian waters in the theoretical context of informal sector studies. Discussing the relationship between shore-based fishermen and fishing trawlers, we pick up the 'most interesting theme' in maritime anthropological studies in West Africa, namely 'what is happening between the two ideal types, what is the development direction, how do the different types of fishing interlock with each other?' (Tvedten and Hersoug, 1992).

BACKGROUND TO NIGERIAN FISHERIES

Successive federal governments have shown little interest in the development or expansion of Nigeria's fisheries.[3] Most of the investment during the 1970s benefited inland fisheries, with investment in extension services around Lake Chad and hatcheries in the East Central region. Support for maritime fisheries resulted in the commissioning of a number of research vessels, the improvement of port facilities, and training and research establishments, particularly the Nigerian Institute of Oceanography and Marine Research. At the same time the tariff regime, a left-over from the civil war, which set a 50 per cent import duty on fish caught and landed by Nigerian-owned fishing vessels, discouraged the development of Nigerian fishing enterprise until it was abolished during the Second Republic.[4]

The operation of modern fishing vessels was therefore left to Nigeria's private sector entrepreneurs, such as the importer of frozen fish Michael Ibru, who in 1963 launched the Osadjere Fishing Company with Japanese assistance (Forrest, 1994). By integrating fishing with distribution and marketing, including a network of cold storage facilities across the country and comprehensive arrangements with networks of fish traders all over Nigeria, Ibru could maintain his dominant position throughout the 1960s and 1970s. In large parts of the country frozen fish was known as 'Ibru fish'.

New entrants soon moved into the sector, following the established pattern of forming joint ventures with overseas partners, which were gradually Africanised. At that early stage the development of the Nigerian fishing fleet owed much to developments in Ghana as a source of know-how, trained seamen and equipment. The second largest trawler fleet today, for example, Obelawo Farcha Fishing Industries, started off in 1971 with four Ghanaian vessels. Officers and crew were also recruited from among the growing community of Ghanaian economic migrants entering Nigeria during the 1970s, and from the resident population of people of Ghanaian descent along the littoral.

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[3] Budgetary allocations to fisheries: 1962–68, £143,000; 1970–74, £602,000; 1975–78, N100,032 million from a total budget of N43 billion; 1978–85, 1 per cent of Agricultural Credit Guarantee Scheme fund (ACGSF) goes to fisheries projects. Source: Amadi (1989).

[4] The second period of civilian rule, 1979–83.

When a more favourable fishing regime was implemented in the 1980s, including the abolition of discriminatory tariffs and the supply of subsidised diesel fuel to licensed trawler operators, a host of new operators joined the fray, including the Modandola Group, Express Fisheries, the Folawiyo Group and the Honeywell Group. Though local productions gained a cost advantage over imports when the naira began to slide on international currency markets, it proved a short-lived advantage for the operators of complex large-scale vessels, heavily dependent on imported inputs which had to be paid for in hard currency. Hardest hit by the economic downturn was the fledgling deep-sea fleet set up in partnership with an Israeli fishing company. By 1995 only half the hundred-odd registered Nigerian trawlers were operating regularly. Most, including the larger ships above 65 ft in length, were laid up waiting for spare parts. The trawl of the coastal fishing grounds was left to the smaller vessels between 30 ft and 45 ft in length powered by 180 h.p. diesel engines. By producing their own ice these trawlers have extended their range significantly. In effect, fuel availability and other factors often cut down the length of fishing trips. Some vessels are out overnight or for a couple of days; others, especially shrimpers, trawl for four to eleven days, but often the trawlers restrict their operations to the fishing grounds outside Lagos. In the peak months between August and November they are expected to catch between 1·5 tonnes and 2 tonnes of fish, mainly croaker, which is packed into 20 kg bags. Hauling the net, sorting the fish, packing, bagging and ice-drying the catch on the plate freezers, before it is sorted into master cartons, are the main tasks of the crew. A vessel may employ ten men in addition to the captain and the engineer (Adetola, 1992). If the fishing is good and the company well supplied with fuel and other inputs, they can continue fishing indefinitely. But the cost and shortage of spare parts, poorly paid crews, captains of questionable loyalty, the limited availability of fuel and relations with the authorities all throw up problems which render trawler operation precarious and instil a 'short term' mentality in many participants (Anetekhan, 1983).

Yet a number of companies have been successful in adapting to this type of operation, including Osadjere Fishing Company, Intercontinental Fishing Company, Ocean Trawling Company, Manicom Fisheries, West Coast Fisheries, Offshore Trawlers and the Hussaini Fishing Companies. They have achieved cost savings by finding alternative suppliers of spare parts, particularly from the Far East, and developing local engineering skills. In order to minimise fuel costs and wear-and-tear of equipment many captains take their vessels only on short trips along the Lagos–Badagry coast. Overheads can be reduced further by simplifying technology, and through less reputable measures, including riding roughshod over legislative restrictions designed to protect the safety of the crews and the interests of the shore-based fishermen. One such infringement which has become common in recent years is particularly relevant for our purposes: it is the intrusion of fishing trawlers into coastal waters reserved for artisanal fishermen.

ARTISANAL FISHERMEN ALONG THE LAGOS–BADAGRY SEABEACH

Nigerian law protects the fishing grounds within two miles of the coast, banning large fishing vessels. The intention behind the legislation is two-fold: as a conservation measure, and to protect the interests of artisanal fishermen who are allowed to cast their nets and leave their traps in these waters. Along the coastal strip between Lagos and Badagry, Nigeria's inshore fisheries have been worked for three generations by a community of fishermen based on what is locally known as the 'Seabeach'. This is a strip of land stretching from the western mouth of Lagos lagoon all the way to Cotonou. Varying from a few hundred feet to several miles in width, this sandstrip, which fronts to the south on to the pounding surf of the Atlantic Ocean while its north-pointing back is gently washed by Badagry creek, is effectively an island insulated by miles of swamp and water from metropolitan Lagos. Most parts of it were uninhabited until the beginning of the century, when groups of fishermen migrated from the Keta lagoon in Ghana to set up temporary fish camps. After a few years several camps had grown into villages which through a process of segmentation and aggregation have spread across the entire Seabeach. In the 1990s there were around thirty villages with a population varying between a few dozen to several hundred, each of which contained at least one net company. These net companies are formed around seine fishing nets, known as *yevuro*,[5] for which the Ewe are famous all along the West African coast (Berron, 1977; Hill, 1986; Jorion, 1988; Nukunya, 1989; Wyllie, 1969).

The technically difficult and risky operation of the seine net can be briefly summarised. The net is carried out to sea by boat and paid out half a mile from shore. The boat returns with the two ends of the rope, which are pulled in over the course of several hours. In many cases the official members of the net company are joined by dependants and fellow villagers, which gives the operation a communal dimension. In some villages work teams are coterminous with residential units, but the success of individual net owners has enabled them to expand and head several companies in villages with much larger populations. Companies typically employ between fifteen and forty full-time members, as well as a high number of assistants charged with storage, guard duties, maintenance and repairs, which need to be carried out constantly. Social differentiation emerges in the division of the catch. One-third accrues to the net owner and another third is shared out in different proportions between the company members; the remainder is used for repairs and replacements and to repay debts. The 'net company' has been described as 'an original system, wholly African, which has the advantage of being communal but which does not reject the notion of profit and gives expression to the formation of capital'.[6]

It is therefore inadequately described as a traditional operation, as it is clearly predicated upon the existence of a market system, functioning all year round, and large urban centres with demand for food. This creates a

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[5] It means the 'white man's net'.
[6] De Surgy (1966: 128–9) as quoted by Hill (1986: 9).

contrast to the fishing practices of many other African groups, which are seasonal, often after the rains, and form one set of tasks in a variegated calendar that is dominated by farming. Furthermore, the object of the fishing is not local self sufficiency, or part of a regional trade cycle in which groups of producers occupy different economic niches and exchange their produce to mutual advantage, something known as the 'starch for protein' exchange (Harms, 1987). Owners of the Ewe net companies, by contrast, are concerned with profit and reinvestment. Observations of Ghanaian artisanal fisheries have attributed this process to the 'penetration of capital' (Alexander, 1982; Palsson, 1990; Platteau, 1990; Vercruisse, 1984), and it has been regarded as one of the many consequences of European contact. Yet, while all net companies fish for profit, many net owners also have a strong sense of communal responsibility and will share a significant portion of the catch among villagers and 'helpers'. In many villages fishing retains features of a collective enterprise, motivated by the values of community reproduction.

Since arriving along the Nigerian shore the Ewe fishermen have achieved modest prosperity on the back of a ceaselessly rising demand for fish in greater Lagos. They have been popular tenants with their landlords, the Awori Yoruba communities across the creek, who never regarded the sea as a resource. But they have invariably been affected by Nigeria's economic decline since the mid-1980s and by the consequences of their own success. While the first settlers landed at the western end of the Nigerian coastline, succeeding village founders have been moving eastwards towards Lagos. Today the entire beach is settled, with no vacant plots left for future villages. Ewe fishermen therefore have to intensify their efforts within the given resource base. There are limited opportunities in farming and in catering for the occasional holiday-maker from Lagos, but their competitive advantage lies in their maritime skills. The seine-net fishing, however, has suffered from the rising operating costs of engines and nets, from overfishing and increasingly from the deleterious intrusions of trawlers. These damage nets and traps with their propellers and deplete limited fish stocks with their voracious appetite. Hugely resented by many of the Ewe fishermen, particularly the net owners, the operation of trawlers has come to represent an opportunity to others. The interaction of artisanal and industrial fisheries off the Nigerian coastline provides an interesting illustration of several theoretical issues raised in the informality debate, particularly concerning sectoral linkages and the issue of *informalisation* (Meagher, 1995).

It is important to recall at this juncture that in the 1960s economists and development planners working on fisheries in other West African countries, particularly Ghana and Senegal, believed that indigenous operators, 'characterised by low capital outlay, and low operational costs, low technology application and labour intensive, poor fish distribution network, local market oriented and low revenue generating, poor processing methods and high post-harvest loss' (Tobor, 1990: 7) were to be superseded by hi-tech fishing trawlers, frozen storage holds and modern management methods. The principal function of the 'traditional sector', represented by paddle-propelled dugouts, was to provide a source of labour for the 'modern' sector (Lawson and Kwei, 1974). The paternalism permeating the policy-making bodies was exemplified by the 1984 World Conference on Fisheries Management organised by the FAO, to which no representatives of artisanal fishing organisations were invited (Le Sann, 1998).

In spite of heavy financial investment and a high degree of international assistance, most state-sponsored capital-intensive fishing fleets in West Africa have failed to come up to expectations (Chauveau and Samba, 1989; Haakenson, 1992). During the 1980s sophisticated imported fishing vessels were being laid up in Ghana and Senegal, owing to a shortage of spare parts, or as a result of plain mismanagement. Yet this had only a negligible effect upon the supply of fish to local markets, where ever-growing volumes of fish products were being turned over.[7] Fish, already a major food item along the West African coast, became even more important in the recessionary 1980s, when alternative sources of protein became too expensive for large sections of the population. Though the importance of fish as food for the poor has been recognised by the Nigerian government, the practical responses came from the canoe, or artisanal, fishermen who were flourishing, in Nigeria as elsewhere in West Africa (Platteau, 1990; Tvedten and Hersoug, 1992), with little or no support from governments and overseas development agencies. Their efforts provide a rare case of economic success on an economically depressed continent.

Maritime anthropological studies in West Africa, South Asia and Latin America have shown that, instead of quietly going out of business, many fishing communities have responded to the opportunities of new markets, have adapted technology and have devised new forms of organisation and of finance.[8] Such changes have included the radical transformation of work practices and economic relations. Status hierarchies have replaced egalitarianism, surplus allocation is being redirected from distribution within the community to the market and individual accumulation, technological upgrading has been accelerated, and middlemen and absentee boat owners are playing an ever more important role (Durrenberger and Palsson, 1987; Kurien, 1978; Moorsom, 1984; Meynen, 1989; Robben, 1989; Platteau, 1990).

Hence a picture emerges of local fishermen as agents of change whose operations are better understood as artisanal activities. Furthermore, artisanal fishermen are not nailed to the masts of their banana boats but perfectly capable of leaving the beach for the industrial fishing fleet. In a declining job market during the mid-1980s men from the Seabeach villages benefited from the expulsion of foreign nationals in 1983, when scores of Ghanaian seamen were among the estimated one million Ghanaian nationals repatriated from Nigeria (Brydon, 1985). Many villagers from the Seabeach, having come into possession of Nigerian registration papers,[9] found work on the trawlers.

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[7] Nigerian coastal artisanal catches, 1985: 146,000 tonnes; 1987: 172,000 tonnes; 1989: 193,000 tonnes (GATT, 1991). Ghanaian catches increased from 27,500 tonnes in 1961 to 264,400 tonnes in 1987 (Henaes, 1991).

[8] These are represented respectively by the net company and fishing co-operative and the share system or tontine (Acheson, 1981).

[9] Thanks largely to the intervention of politicians grouped around the Lagos state governor Lateef Jakande.

Some men, after establishing themselves within particular companies, came to act as recruitment agents in their native villages, providing new generations of young men with jobs and hope for the future. But this move into the industrial sector does not present a unidirectional movement in accordance with modernisation theory. Many seamen working on the trawlers today are saving up for a boat, a seine net and other gear. They are working for a number of years before returning to the beach to set up their own net companies and other related enterprises. If these data are fed into the informality model it transpires that many workers enter the formal sector temporarily in order to accumulate the means and to a lesser extent the know-how which is then invested in the informal sector.

The evidence of the constant cross-over of personnel and technology therefore points towards an economy in which interrelationships rather than distinct sectors are the norm. Several prominent economic studies stipulate that such linkages between the sectors deliver greater efficiency and are essentially benign (ILO 1985; World Bank, 1989). Most authors stress the importance of forward linkages, with formal sector enterprises procuring raw materials, labour, services and other inputs from informal sector operators (Traub, 1986; Trager, 1987; Meagher and Yunusa, 1991). At the other end of the process many informal activities, such as the recycling of scrap metal or empty containers, rely on a high formal sector input content but not as part of a contractual arrangement between partners (Meagher, 1995). There is in fact hardly any information on informal sector operators contracting formal sector firms to provide essential inputs. This is partly a definitional problem, as such an operation, by evading the regulatory authorities (including the tax office), would automatically fall into the informal sector. More important, most informal sector studies assume that informal sector operators lack either the financial muscle or the organisational acumen to enter into productive relations with formal sector companies in any other capacity than as subcontractor. The relationship is therefore driven entirely by formal sector firms; under pressure from rising competition, formal sector firms defend their profits by locating part of the process in the informal sector. In effect this translates into longer working hours, declining remuneration for employees, poor working conditions and minimal social benefits, low quality control and little customer protection (Castells and Portes, 1989). Described as *informalisation*, it is part of a restructuring process which, contrary to the neo-liberal argument of efficiency and appropriateness, is essentially exploitative.

While the experience of the fishing sector underlines the contention that structural adjustment is accompanied by deteriorating working conditions and declining wages, there is also evidence of backward linkages—with formal sector companies providing informal sector operators with inputs—and of a host of those informal activities which punctuate the working lives of formal sector employees. This last point particularly serves as a reminder that in his original scheme Hart had wisely refrained from categorising particular kinds of people but had emphasised activities or roles. This means that within the same occupation an individual may play several different roles in accordance with different activities (Hart, 1973: 88). The difficulty of maintaining the sectoral distinctions proposed by the informality paradigm become clear once we return to the beach to construe the 'sectoral biography' of one commodity.

THE LEGO TRADE

Jimo Kukutsi, the son of a prominent chief from the village of Ibeshi, had worked 'in town' for several years before returning to the beach with enough money to buy himself an engine for one of his father's boats. He was intent on entering the lucrative fishing industry but had no intention of forming a net company. Seine net fishing is labour-intensive and therefore requires astute management skills and a permanent commitment to the village. Jimo used his engine instead to set traps for shrimp farther away from shore, and to go after herring for several days at a time during the *shawa* season. But that left him still dependent on the whims of his crew and the vagaries of the sea. Moreover, fishing with a small team was backbreakingly hard work. In 1989 Jimo decided to change the nature of his operation. Acting on the information of a relative, he approached a trawler that had been seen steaming past the village on previous occasions. As it returned, cruising along the coast showing little interest in fishing, Jimo set off in his boat to parley with the captain. Drawing near, he found that several members of the crew were Ewe-speakers, one even from a neighbouring village, with whom he quickly established a *rapport*.

This encounter launched Jimo's career as a 'lego' trader. Within a few years he had replaced his engine, acquired a new boat and gained a reputation in the village as one of the successful young men. His operation was based on close relations with the fishwives, on the one hand, and with the fishing trawlers on the other. He could keep the team numbers down and maximise his own profit. A detailed account of the series of transactions which deliver the fish from the trawler on to the consumer's plate illustrates the web of interrelationships and linkages across different sectors.

The barracuda's tale. Early May 1995. Less than a mile from Ibeshi Seabeach a trawler belonging to Ijora Trawlers is met by Jimo Kukutsi, and a number of crates of frozen fish are unloaded over the side of the vessel on to his banana boat, which returns to the beach. A large number of women have assembled from neighbouring villages and, by the miracle of 'informal' communication networks, from as far as the market town of Ojo. The boat is carried to the beach, the twenty crates of frozen fish are unloaded and auctioned off. Women who have advanced money, such as Yorxor Dumeda, get a better price and first choice. For the 1,000 naira[10] she paid to Jimo Kukutsi Yorxor obtains one and a half 30 kg cartons, and wastes no time in heading off for the lagoon. She could have taken the fish to her compound and smoked them, but the quality of the catch is high—barracuda caught that morning—and it is only midday.

From the lagoon side of Ilashe Seabeach Yorxor hails a banana boat that ferries her with thirty other people to Ojo, about an hour later. In the market

[10] At the time (May 1995) the exchange rate was £1 to 130 naira.

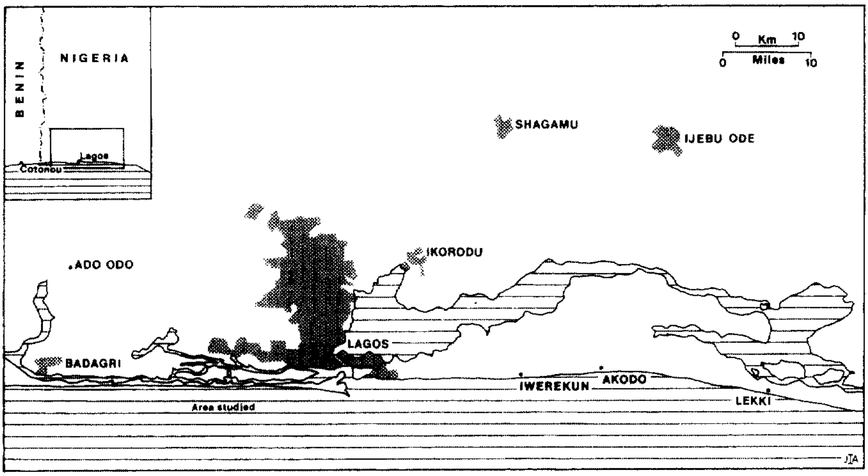

FIG. 1. The 'sea beaches' of western Nigeria

Yorxor has no problem disposing of her thawing barracudas for a cool 2,000 naira, loads up with beer, soft drinks, batteries and other petty trading goods for her retail enterprise in the village and returns to the quay for a boat back to Ilashe Seabeach.

The fish, already separated into several lots, is meanwhile waiting for customers in the shade of Funmi Adewale's stall in the fish section of Ojo market. There is keen competition between the fishwives, so she is lucky to sell her biggest fish, a beautiful specimen of 4–5 kg, for 800 naira a couple of hours later. Her buyer is Yisa Zannu, a former fisherman, who has just managed to get his car back on the road. He buys several lots of top-quality fish, which he stacks in the back of the Peugeot 504 under the guard of his son before driving into Lagos. Going against the run of the traffic, he avoids the worst of the 'go-slows' and reaches Ikeja[11] in the late afternoon. His clients are the big hotels, including the Hilton near the airport, where he knows one of the kitchen staff. Getting there at around four o'clock, he sells the barracuda for 2,000 naira, as well as some mackerel. His friend, Jean, a chef from the Benin Republic and of the same ethnic group,[12] prepares the fish, which is cut into several portions for main courses, while the offcuts are used in the soup. One barracuda steak at the Hilton restaurant costs 1,250 naira plus tax.

[11] A prosperous district of Lagos first developed as an administrative centre by the colonial government, which contains the airport, the state government offices and several international hotels.
[12] Ogu or Gun.

That evening a European accounting consultant, working on a short-term contract for a food multinational in Nigeria, dines at the hotel. He has a mutually advantageous understanding with the head waiter to doctor his expense receipts. The conglomerate which owns the hotel franchise also controls Ijora Trawlers: it is a family business, whose top managers and decision makers are very close.[13]

The overboard sale of fish, quite common along the West African coast today, is said to have originated on shrimping trawlers which, licensed to fish only a specified quantity of shrimp, used to dump their by-catch[14] of low-value fish overboard until shore-based fishermen, their vessels equipped with engines, offered them money for it (Tvedten and Hersoug, 1992; Tobor, 1990). The trawler captains agreed to sell the fish that was normally 'let go', hence the trade became known as 'lego'. It turns out that in practice industrial and artisanal, formal and informal, operators are so closely intertwined that people and products continually shuttle across the divide from one sector to another. The barracuda is caught by a trawler, sold overboard to a banana boat, passes along three informal market vendors, to return to a formal sector hotel, to aid and abet an informal arrangement between two formal sector employees. Though typical of Nigeria in more than one sense, close working relations between artisanal and industrial fishermen have been reported from all along the West African coast. In Ghana, where not only trawlers but even international factory ships are licensed to operate, the 'by-catch' is known as 'dumping fish' and the foreign vessels are known as 'the Koreans' (Overa, 1995). In Senegal roles are reversed. Korean ships pick up a number of local pirogues, sail out to fisheries which could not normally be reached by shore-based craft, drop the pirogues off and then buy their catch off them (Parfit, 1995).

In contrast to such 'formal' arrangements the sale of any part of the catch constitutes theft of company property. But the company is already implicated in a breach of the law by allowing—or even encouraging—the captain to intrude into the protected coastal zone. Furthermore, the loss of a certain percentage is factored into the costing of the fishing operation and partly made up for by compression of the wages of officers and men. The operators of the vessel have abandoned the attempt to control every aspect of the fishing operation as long as a profit is generated. As this is likely to be repeated on each vessel of the fleet, it means that even within the trawler fisheries of the formal sector a substantial part of operations goes unrecorded. If we add to that the numerous transactions before the barracuda resurfaces in the rigorous accounts kept by the international hotel, the fish has gained much of its added value in the informal sector.

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[13] Companies run along family lines were consigned to the informal sector (ILO, 1972; Sethuraman, 1981). The author reserves the right to alter the names of individuals and institutions to convey the sense of organisation.

[14] The by-catch being that part of the catch which is discarded by the vessel, usually because it contains fish of low economic value or fish which it is illegal to catch, e.g. undersize tuna or protected species like turtle or dolphin.

The difficulties inherent in the informality dichotomy are becoming increasingly apparent. Jimo Kukutsi's pre-financed expedition on his powered banana boat shows that, strictly speaking, neither capitalisation nor technology provides criteria for differentiation. A distinction could be drawn on the basis of size and scale, but as a general scheme that would be to consign many a law-abiding, tax-paying individual operator, including expatriate development consultants, to the informal sector while drug-running syndicates and prostitution rings joined Shell in the formal sector. This passing reference to criminal organisations leads us to the crux of the informality paradigm, and its basic assumption of a contrasting formal sector operating within the confines of the law. It is at this juncture that the model begins to unravel when subjected to scrutiny. It serves to remind us that the pioneers of informality were working in the afterglow of the colonial state when they anchored the formal sector in the institutions of the state and in the local subsidiaries of multinational companies. There have been significant revisions in the past twenty years, but at the time when informality was first formulated it was widely assumed that independent African states would pursue a Western path to development and, in keeping with a Weberian vision of the rational state and modernisation, introduce ordered regulation and set up a supervisory regime. Once again the experience from fishing suggests that, twenty-five years on, the agencies of the Nigerian state use the powers vested in them to very different ends. While these may be entirely rational they rarely seem to coincide with the identified national interest in accordance with which they were called into being in the first place.

The 'Yinka'. The trawler *Yinka* has been out on a three-day fishing trip along the coastline. It has fifteen tons of frozen fish in the hold, but the engine has developed problems which the engineer has not been able to sort out. Spare parts will be required which may not be available at the docks and may have to be imported. As a result the crew do not know how long it will be before they are able to go out again. They know plenty of other ships which have been stranded by maintenance problems, as the high cost of foreign exchange has crippled the Nigerian fishing and shrimping industry. Only the captain can be sure that the company will look after him; his crew are likely to find themselves hanging about the harbour gates, looking for work elsewhere. It is early morning when the trawler enters Lagos harbour, keeping to the middle of the channel. After a few minutes the ocean swell gives way to the calm waters of Lagos lagoon, and the built-up shoreline of Victoria Island and Lagos Island comes into view. As the trawler continues making headway towards its anchorage at Apapa two grey speedboats, 9 ft long, leave a quay at Victoria Island and head straight for the fishing vessel. Their movements are copied by a similar boat on the western side of the bay. The men on board wear uniforms, and the words ANTI-CRIME PATROL come gradually into view along the boats' long, sleek hulls. As the first one reaches the trawler the fishing vessel drops its speed, the boat runs alongside and several officers clamber aboard. Several duties need taking care of: licences need to be inspected; trawlers have to prove that they are *bona fide* fishing vessels and not bringing in petrol; they are also searched for contraband, such as rice or spare engine parts from Benin Republic. The mesh size of the nets has to be inspected as well as the number of cartons. The inspection does not take long. After a while, members of the trawler's crew move to the side and hand over cartons of fish to the officers who have remained in the boat. The process is repeated with two, three, four other boats, depending on the time of day and the state of operations.

The homecoming of the *Yinka* is an example of policy failure in practice, as the officials entrusted with implementation pursue a very different set of objectives from what the law intended. Their concern is neither to secure compliance with the letter of the law nor to uphold the conservationist spirit behind it. Instead, any existing set of regulations, however well designed, is instrumentalised merely to enhance the revenue-gathering powers of the law enforcement officers. The extent to which incoming trawlers' catch is being diverted is illustrated by the fact that on Victoria Island—the wealthiest part of Lagos—fish sales are dominated by the wives of police and servicemen.

THE STATE

Hence the discussion of the informality paradigm leads eventually to the role of the state as the principal referent and the silent guarantor of the 'formal sector'. Yet the evidence derived from fishing suggests that, far from maintaining detached disinterest, the agencies of the state are deeply involved as players in the very set of processes they are supposed to be regulating. This tension in the relationship between officeholder and office was observed in different instances shortly after Nigerian independence. First the impersonal neutrality of office was replaced by the personal relations of the officeholders. Second, a frenetic activism swept through the corridors of the administration as the 'the adamantine rectitude of early colonial trusteeship has been replaced by an urge to get things done' (Rimmer, 1978: 149). Several dramatic changes of government, major shifts in development policy and several reorganisations of the institutional infrastructure later, the frenetic activism has been overtaken by lassitude in policy implementation. But the subordination of procedural mechanisms to the personal requirements of the officeholder have become deeply entrenched and are cogently described as 'prebendalism' (Joseph, 1987). According to Weber (1995: 207) a prebend is an office assigned to the official by the lord—in this case the state—from which economic benefits are to be drawn in recompense for the fulfilment of actual or fictitious obligations. The notion of 'prebendalism' explains the systematic abuse of office, not as corruption or as breach, but as a rule of the system. It is particularly pertinent to Nigeria, where, as in other African countries, public office has become central to individual advancement as all other organisational elements of economy and society have been dwarfed by the modern state (Diamond, 1988: 30). The significance of getting a slice of what in Nigeria is graphically described as the 'national cake' is such that state office and the attendant benefits are the principal prize for which individuals, and the sectional groupings they claim to represent, compete (Bayart, 1993; Cruise O'Brien *et al.*, 1979). The prodigious possibilities of accumulation which issued from the oil bonanza only accentuated 'prebendal attitudes', at the expense of any lingering notions of public duty. Since the dramatic contraction of the economy in the early 1980s the pursuit of riches has been replaced by concern for sheer survival. After years of rampant inflation salaries have been eroded, leaving public office in the security services, the education and health sectors, administration and the judiciary with woefully inadequate levels of remuneration. Today civil servants need to find extra-curricular resources in order to feed their families, and readily mobilise the powers inherent in their office.

As a feature of African politics the preponderance of 'prebendal attitudes' has been identified across the continent and trenchantly defined as the 'politics of the belly' (Bayart, 1993). It has generated a lively debate on the nature of the African state, provided the intellectual background and justification of structural adjustment programmes designed to reduce the power and capacity of the state, and fed into the rising popularity of the notion of 'civil society'.[15] Among a growing number of Africanist scholars there is a conviction that African states have long abandoned the road to development and the attempt at emulating 'Western' forms of government. Recent publications have suggested that the 'disorder' which characterises public life in most African countries is deliberately engineered by the political elites. The development *impasse* generates benefits for those who through contacts and hedging have turned dependence and uncertainty into a resource (Chabal and Daloz, 1999). In this environment corruption becomes a pervasive feature of the system. Trickling down from ruling regimes described as kleptocracies, 'the criminalisation of politics and of the state may be regarded as the routinisation, at the very heart of governmental institutions, of practices whose criminal nature is patent' (Bayart *et al.*, 1999).

This disenchantment with the state has critical consequences for informal sector theories which have not as yet been properly evaluated. The main aim of most studies of the informal, hidden or real economy has been to demonstrate the magnitude of operations in this sphere and to unmask the venality, incompetence and surreal character of the state (McGaffey, 1987, 1991). By concentrating on the empirical aspects most informal sector scholars have failed to draw the logical conclusion of these findings: that the dissolution of the state as they described it led inexorably to the collapse of the informality paradigm. As a paired negation each marker depends on the integrity of the opposing term. But with criminalisation the key referent of formality has defected across the binary divide, and become absorbed by informality. The rest is simple: no formal sector, no informal sector.

[15] The populist enthusiasm for the dynamism of African associational life (Bratton, 1989), celebrated by a range of scholars from different disciplines, coincided with the assault on the state by political scientists and economists on the political right. Adherents of the New Political Economy in the 1980s constructed political self-interest and institutional corruption into an argument which denied developing-country politicians 'their sincerity, their merit and, ultimately, their right to govern' (Mosely *et al.*, 1991: 13). In conjunction, these theoretical formulations lend legitimacy to the increasing displacement of African state agencies by technocrats from multilateral organisations.

When scholars continue to apply informality they do in fact invoke the very fiction which informal sector studies have gone to great lengths to explode—the convenient myth of the benevolent state. Alternatively they set the African informal sector in contrast to an international formality of which they themselves no doubt form part. In other words, Africa at large presents an informal counterpart to the formal international—read 'Western'—standards, manifested in trans-national companies, government representatives, multilateral agencies and NGOs. A position anticipated by Bayart's, whose definition of legality and criminality is borrowed from 'international law, international organisations, and international morality (1999: 15). Little consideration is given to the fact that African voices are at best marginal when the *mores* of international morality are formulated, not to speak of the derisory role played by African institutions in the supervision and implementation of international law.

THE INFORMAL STATE

Unlike other spheres of macro-economic and political management, where competences and decision-making powers are being increasingly transferred from national states to international technocracies, the distribution of international fisheries resources is determined by the assertion of national interest, in the developed as well as in the developing countries. Since few African countries have the capacity to develop their Economic Exclusion Zones,[16] many, led by Senegal, Côte d'Ivoire and Mauritania, seek to exploit their resources by issuing licences to international fishing companies in so-called 'deep-sea joint ventures'. Currently foreign fleets account for close on 40 per cent of total catches in African waters (Tvedten and Hersoug, 1992), which amounts effectively to a transfer of protein from African to developed countries. The figure does not take account of the illegal—that is, unlicensed—fishing by foreign vessels in the waters of countries lacking the ability to police their EEZ effectively. As fish stocks are finite, it is imperative for African countries to defend this valuable resource and maximise the benefits for their own populations. In spite of the prebendal limitations, only the state has the organisational capacity, the legitimacy and the resources to police territorial waters against foreign intrusion and enforce the licensing regime in the domestic fishing fleet.

While the experience of the *Yinka* discourages optimism, there are precedents in fishing policy where government intervention has produced beneficial results. Since 1965 the use of seine nets in the lagoon fisheries has been banned by order of Lagos State High Court, because of the wastage involved. Most fishermen agree that the ban has been effective (Klein, 1998). Fishermen have also sought the assistance of the authorities when trawlers damage nets or traps within the two-mile exclusion zone. Though informants disagreed about the effectiveness of this course of action, which

[16] Approved by the Organisation of African Unity and the Non-aligned Movement at 200 miles in 1973.

depends on the status of the individual fisherman registering the complaint and of the fishing company in question, the secretary of the Lagos State Fishermen's Union at Badagry was adamant that he was able to obtain redress through the courts. As long as the details of the vessel were reported, and the witnesses were credible, he could obtain recompense either directly from the company or, if they failed to see him, through the intercession of the navy. Trawlers accused of spoilage were liable to be seized by the navy until the case was settled.

The status and connections of plaintiff as well as of officeholder are crucial to the success of any action. The secretary's open line of communication with the navy owed much to his brother, an active naval officer who shared his concern about the rights of artisanal fishermen. Certain fishing companies, in turn, were partially owned by high-ranking figures in the government, so-called 'godfathers' and were practically immune from prosecution. Yet every political system is permeated by personal relations, favours, alliances and rivalries. Too often the identification (and critique) of prebendal attitudes in African officialdom is premised upon an assimilation of the ideal type of a Weberian, rational bureaucracy with the existing instances in Western states. Yet, as 1999 events in the European Commission testify, prebendal attitudes are not a phenomenon particular to, or monopolised by, African countries. The risible level of remuneration for officers and men in the marine police suggest instead that resource constraints remain the single most important factor in explaining the instrumentalisation of office for other purposes. Nor should it be assumed that all exertions by Nigerian officeholders are motivated by self-interest. Many officials spend much of their time doing their duty, while the populace, however cynical, maintains expectations of what constitutes proper official conduct. It is as if the social imaginary pursues the idea of a rule-governed, normative Nigeria as a long-term aspiration. For the moment we suggest the term 'informal state' not because the state is vacuous (Chabal and Daloz, 1999) but because it is part of an on-going project.

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ABSTRACT

The expansion of Nigeria's artisanal fisheries has been a rare economic success story during the 1980s. Without assistance from government agencies the canoe fishermen, many of them Ghanaian migrants, have responded successfully to the opportunities offered by the Lagos market. In recent years declining fish stocks and competition from trawlers have forced shore-based fishermen to adapt their operations to changing circumstances. In describing a number of such responses the article tackles a number of wider themes in economic anthropology and African studies. Contrasting the opposition and co-operation of industrial and artisanal fisheries throws an interesting light on the informal sector debates, while the role played by the marine police and the navy feeds into the discussion on the African state.

RÉSUMÉ

L'essor de la pêche artisanale au Nigeria fut l'une des rares réussites économiques des années 80. Sans assistance des agences gouvernementales, les pêcheurs en pirogues, migrants ghanéens pour une grande part, ont réagi avec succès aux

opportunités offertes par le marché de Lagos. Au cours de ces dernières années, la diminution des réserves de poissons et la concurrence des chalutiers ont forcé les pêcheurs côtiers à adapter leurs activités à cette nouvelle situation. En décrivant un certain nombre de ces réactions, l'article aborde plusieurs thèmes plus larges d'études économiques anthropologiques et africaines. Faisant ressortir le contraste entre opposition et coopération de la pêche industrielle et de la pêche artisanale, il jette une lumière intéressante sur les débats qui ont lieu au sein du secteur informel, tandis que le rôle de la police maritime et de la marine alimente le débat sur l'état africain.